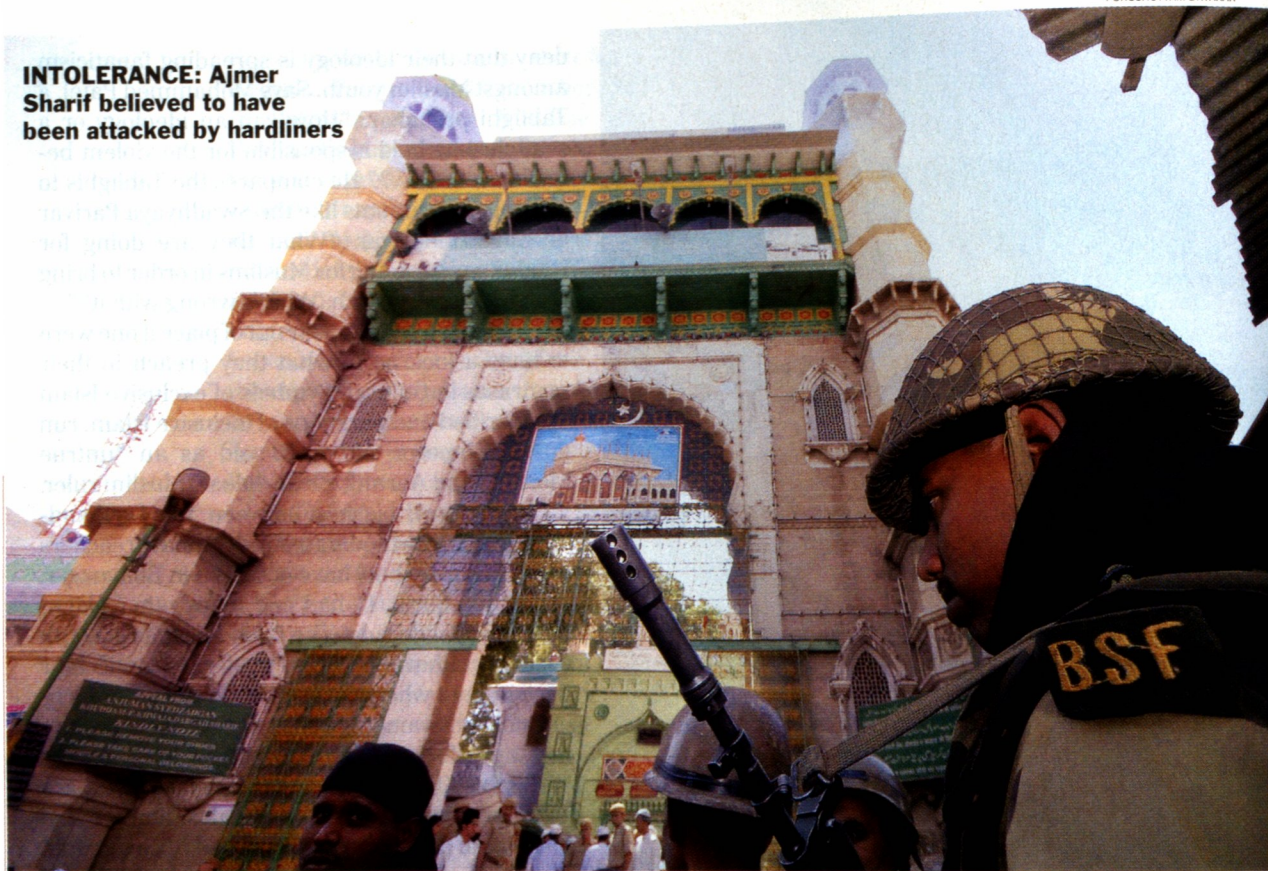


INTOLERANCE: Ajmer Sharif believed to have been attacked by hardliners



About 30 per cent of moderate mosques have been taken over by hardliners who donate money for repairs and appoint their priests.

to explain why their founder emphasises mullah hegemony similar to Aryan hegemony," says M.N. Karassery, writer and professor at the Calicut University.

With a growing realisation that their narrow interpretation of Islam is inspiring terrorism, the Deobandis are distancing themselves from terror acts and condemned these for the first time. On February 25, the Darul Uloom Deoband and other organisations organised a rally declaring terrorism as un-Islamic and against the Koran, condemned the maligning of madrasas and Muslims and exhorted the latter to continue their loyalty to their motherland. The Deoband influence transcends borders and has the potential to influence Muslims worldwide. Over the next few weeks, other Muslim organisations held similar conferences.

In spite of its declared stance against terrorism, by preaching puritan Islam, hardliners run the risk of pushing Muslim youths to the thin line that divides fundamentalism and terrorism. Critics of neo-fundamentalist movements argue that groups like Al Qaeda find cadre from groups

who define their Islamic politics primarily as encouragement of a narrow range of Islamic practices and symbols and whose background has nothing to do with traditional Islamic preaching.

The solution to countering the spread of fundamentalism may well lie in encouraging the moderates. Between June 2 and 4, representatives of the British and Indian home ministries sat down for a series of meetings discussing their experiences of terrorism. The meeting comprised India's Intelligence Bureau, UK's MI5 and senior police officials. Their verdict was unanimous. Both sides would have to work to actively encourage moderates, which has worked well in the UK where community elders led the police to elaborate plans to serial-bomb aircraft in 2006. In India, this would mean encouraging the Sufis. Isolated peace efforts have come from the Sufi Foundation of India led by Hazrat Syed Mohammad Jilani Ashraf Kichhauchhvi, who is busy creating a Sufi corridor. But it will take many more deeds than mere words if the bigger battle against fundamentalism is to be won.

with Farzand Ahmed and Shafi Rahman